thought possible. Monty is very calm too. There is no supernatural, other-worldly talent that is dragging me towards this, no special skill or thoughtless magic that occurs. This is sheer, slightly timid, everyday denial. With each successful one, the blocks gather some Hollywood momentum, our survival developing a little panache – some high elbows, some holding of the pose.

While this is happening, I am trying to read the game situation. It's quite confusing. Obviously if we can last, we can rescue the draw. But, the other survival path is to go past the Australian total and then bat out for long enough that there isn't time for them to bat again. The umpires are clearly trying to work it out on the hop, just as we are. Both their watches are checked and then aligned with the big clock at Sophia Gardens. I ask Aleem Dar, again and again, what the situation is. There is a slight language barrier problem, and I am finding it hard to understand with clarity when the cut-off time is. I don't think even he knows. Forget it, I tell Monty. Let's just keep batting. Keep surviving. Maybe even, something else occurring to me, we could start killing time.

I decide that maybe I need a new pair of gloves. I gesture confidently to the dressing room. New gloves please. Twelfth man Bilal Shafayat runs on with jumpers and gloves. I'm not even sure whose gloves they are, but they are definitely not mine. I only own this pair I've got on. I decide I don't need new gloves, actually. Bilal confirms the time to me – bat until ten to seven. 'Got it,' I tell him, before realising my shoelaces need tying again, and while I'm tying them, that maybe there's something in my eye too. When I look up, Ricky Ponting is next to me, scowling. It occurs to me, as he does, that we might be winning the mind games. He is very unhappy. I ignore him and pretend to be in my batting zone.

The second time Bilal Shafayat is sent out, this time he is with our physio, Steve McCague. Steve is Australian and his hero is Ricky Ponting. It's an unfortunate place to meet his childhood idol given the game situation and the mood he finds him in. Ponting takes one look at him, a million more excuses being made to kill some time, and says, 'What are you doing here, you fat c**t?' I don't think it was how Steve had imagined his first conversation with his all-time hero. As Steve leaves, body language bowed but sacrifice for the team taken, I remember the Ponting that had been run out in 2005 by the substitute fielder, Gary Pratt. Watching as a fan on the